

ANGRY HILLS
People at the Feb. 3 protest rally in Leh

ANI

LADAKH

BITTER FIGHT FOR BETTER

By Moazum Mohammad

In October last year, the National Conference (NC) and Congress alliance had swept the elections to the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council in Kargil, indicating a significant shift in local sentiment. Though the council's purview is restricted to tax collection and some local governance, the victory in the 'hyperlocal election' was seen as an expression of the anger against the ruling BJP at the Centre, particularly after the abrogation of Article 370. The defeat came amid the saffron party's attempt to expand its base in the region and when it had many developments to its credit, including fulfilling a long-standing demand of Union territory (UT) status for Ladakh.

Some six months on, the region is again facing unrest ahead of the crucial Lok Sabha election. On February 3, in the freezing cold, a massive protest march navigated the deserted streets from the NDS Stadium to the Polo Ground in Leh to renew their demands. People from even the remotest villages joined in, and the shutdown was total. They have five key demands: statehood for Ladakh, constitutional safeguards for it under the Sixth Schedule, recruitment and job reservation for local youth, establishing a Public Service Commission for the region and, last but not least, raising the number of Ladakh's parliamentary seats from one to two.

The protest, spearheaded by the Leh Apex Body and the Kargil Democratic Alliance, has support from everyone other than the BJP. Historically, the two districts of Ladakh, predominantly Buddhist Leh and Muslim-majority Kargil, have had ideologically and politically divergent stands on most issues. Yet all the